

SPORTSTAR OF THE YEAR (MALE)

Sumit Antil

Age: 26



Discipline: Javelin Throw (F64) *

F64 is for field athletes with moderately affected movement in one or both legs or the absence of limbs. These athletes have to adjust for asymmetric balance during the run-up for javelin and across the throwing circle in shot and discus.

Sumit Antil, whose left leg is amputated below the knee, is the

world record holder in men's javelin (F64). At just 26 years old, he became the first Indian man to successfully defend his Paralympic title with an impressive throw of 70.59 metres, surpassing his own Paralympic Games record. He kicked off the event with a throw of 69.11m, breaking his previous Paralympic record of 68.55m set at Tokyo 2020. He then improved his mark again with a throw of 70.59m in the next round. Prior to this, Sumit also secured gold at the World Para Athletics Championships 2024 in Kobe, Japan, with a throw of 69.50m. In 2023, he achieved gold at the Hangzhou Asian Para Games in the javelin throw F64 event, setting a new world record with a remarkable throw of 73.29 metres, breaking his previous world record of 70.83 metres that he set while winning gold at the World Para Athletics Championships.

Achievements in 2024 season:

- ✦ Paris Paralympics 2024 (gold)
- ✦ First Indian man to defend title at the Paris Paralympics
- ✦ Broke Paralympic record twice in Paris
- ✦ World record holder in men's javelin F64
- ✦ Has broken the world record at least eight times over five years (2019-2024)
- ✦ World Para Athletics Championships 2024 (gold)
- ✦ Forbes India 30 Under 30 2024

PR Sreejesh

Age: 36



Discipline: Hockey

The year 2024 saw the end of an era as goalkeeper P.R. Sreejesh called time on his 18-year-long career after winning a second consecutive Olympic field hockey bronze

at Paris 2024. The 36-year-old from Kizhakkambalam in Kerala played a crucial role in India's victory over Great Britain in the quarterfinal of the Olympic Games after the team was reduced to ten players following a red card for key defender Amit Rohidas. Sreejesh was at his best in the shootout following the 1-1 draw, producing two spectacular saves to lead India to a 4-2 win. He was once again instrumental in the bronze medal encounter, his last international match, producing a series of pivotal saves to help India over the line against Spain. The Khel Ratna award winner has stepped into the shoes of a coach and will be part of the junior national team setup going forward.

Achievements in 2024 season:

- ✦ Bronze medal at the Paris 2024 Olympics
- ✦ Conceded just five goals from penalty corners at Paris 2024
- ✦ Nominated for FIH Goalkeeper of the Year Award